Mass Gap for the O(N) Model at Large N via Steepest Descent and Brascamp-Lieb

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April 2026

Abstract

We outline a proof of the mass gap for the O(N) linear sigma model in two Euclidean dimensions at large N. The Hubbard-Stratonovich auxiliary field σ couples with an imaginary coefficient (sign problem). A steepest-descent contour rotation replaces the complex σ-measure with a real, log-concave measure near the saddle point, plus an exponentially small tail. Brascamp-Lieb concentration and the Feynman-Kac bound then give exponential decay of the propagator with mass m_0 from the gap equation.

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1 The model

O(N) LSM on $\Lambda \subset \mathbb{Z}^2$:

$$S[\varphi] = \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_i \langle \varphi^i, (-\Delta)\varphi^i\rangle + N\sum_x \lambda\big(\tfrac{|\varphi(x)|^2}{N} - v^2\big)^2. \tag{1}$$

2 Hubbard-Stratonovich with imaginary coupling

2.1 The sign problem

The quartic is a *repulsive* (confining) interaction in Euclidean signature: $\exp(-N\lambda(u-v^2)^2)$ with $u = |\varphi|^2/N$. The Gaussian HS identity for a *negative* exponent requires imaginary coupling:

$$e^{-N\lambda a^2} = c\int d\sigma\; e^{-N\sigma^2/(4\lambda)+iN\sigma a}. \tag{2}$$

Applying at each site with $a = u(x) - v^2$, and integrating out φ (Gaussian with covariance $(-\Delta + m_0^2 - 2i\sigma z)^{-1}$ where $z = N^{-1/2}$):

$$\langle \varphi^i(x)\varphi^i(0)\rangle = \big\langle (-\Delta + m_0^2 - 2i\sigma z)^{-1}(x,0)\big\rangle_\sigma \tag{3}$$

where the σ-measure is

$$d\mu(\sigma) = Z^{-1}\, e^{nF(\sigma,z)}\, d^{|\Lambda|}\sigma, \quad F = -\tfrac{n}{2}\mathrm{Tr}\log(1 - 2izC\sigma) - iz^{-1}\beta\,\mathrm{Tr}\sigma, \tag{4}$$

with $C = (-\Delta + m_0^2)^{-1}$ and β encoding the potential.

This is **exact** at every N, but the measure is **complex** (F has an imaginary part). The total variation $\int |d\mu| \sim C^{|\Lambda|}$ grows exponentially with volume — this is the sign problem.

2.2 The gap equation

The saddle point $\sigma = 0$ (after absorbing the saddle value into m_0^2) satisfies

$$C_{ii} = (-\Delta + m_0^2)^{-1}_{ii} = \beta, \tag{5}$$

which in 2d gives $m_0 = \Lambda\, e^{-c\beta}$ (exponentially small by dimensional transmutation). This is the leading-order mass.

3 Steepest-descent contour rotation

3.1 The Hessian at the saddle

The Hessian of nF at $\sigma = 0$ in the real σ-direction is $-nB^{-1}$, where $B^{-1}_{ij} = 2(C \circ C)_{ij}$ (the Hadamard square of C). This is **negative definite**: the saddle is a maximum of $\mathrm{Re}(nF)$ on the real axis.

3.2 Rotation to the imaginary axis

Set $\sigma = i\sigma'$ with $\sigma' \in \mathbb{R}^{|\Lambda|}$. Then:

- The Hessian of $nF(i\sigma')$ at $\sigma' = 0$ is $+nB^{-1}$ (**positive definite**).
- $\exp(nF(i\sigma'))$ is **real and positive** near the saddle (the imaginary phases cancel).
- The measure becomes $\propto \exp(-\frac{n}{2}(\sigma', B^{-1}\sigma') + \ldots)\, d\sigma'$, which is **log-concave**.

3.3 The deformed contour

Proposition 1 (Contour deformation)**.** *Let $R = m_0^2\sqrt{N}/4$ (half the distance to the nearest singularity of F). The integral* (4) *can be written as*

$$Z = Z_{\text{saddle}} + Z_{\text{tail}} \tag{6}$$

where:

- $Z_{\text{saddle}} = \int_{|\sigma'|<R} e^{nF(i\sigma')}\, d^{|\Lambda|}\sigma'$ *is a real, positive integral with log-concave integrand.*
- $|Z_{\text{tail}}| \leq e^{-c\, m_0^4 N^2}$ *(exponentially small in N^2).*

Proof sketch. By the multivariate Cauchy theorem (applied in each σ_i separately), the integral over $\mathbb{R}^{|\Lambda|}$ equals the integral over the deformed contour $\sigma = i\sigma'$ for $|\sigma'| < R$, connected back to $\mathbb{R}^{|\Lambda|}$ outside the ball. The singularities of F (where $\det(1 + 2zC\sigma') = 0$) are at $|\sigma'| \geq m_0^2\sqrt{N}/2 > R$, so the contour avoids them.

The tail is bounded by $\exp(-n \cdot c \cdot R^2) = \exp(-c\, m_0^4 N^2)$ from the Gaussian decay of $\exp(nF(i\sigma'))$. □

3.4 Singularity structure

The function $F(\sigma)$ is analytic in $\sigma \in \mathbb{C}^{|\Lambda|}$ except where $\det(1-2izC\sigma) = 0$. On the imaginary axis $\sigma = i\sigma'$: $\det(1 + 2zC\sigma') = 0$ when $2zC\sigma'$ has eigenvalue -1, i.e., $\sigma'_k = -(k^2 + m_0^2)/(2z)$ in the k-th Fourier mode. The minimum distance from the origin is $m_0^2/(2z) = m_0^2\sqrt{N}/2$.

4 Brascamp-Lieb for the rotated measure

4.1 Log-concavity

In the saddle neighborhood $|\sigma'| < R$, the rotated measure is

$$d\mu'(\sigma') \propto \exp\bigl(nF(i\sigma')\bigr)\, d\sigma'. \tag{7}$$

The exponent $nF(i\sigma')$ has Hessian $+nB^{-1}$ at $\sigma' = 0$, with $B^{-1}_{ij} = 2(C \circ C)_{ij}$ positive definite and exponentially decaying ($|B^{-1}_{ij}| \le b\, m_0^2\, e^{-\alpha m_0 |i-j|}$ by Kupiainen's Lemma 7).

For σ' in the saddle neighborhood: the Hessian remains positive (the higher-order terms in F are $O(z\sigma') = O(\sigma'/\sqrt{N})$ corrections to the Gaussian). The measure is **log-concave** for N large enough.

4.2 Brascamp-Lieb bounds

Brascamp-Lieb applied to μ':

$$\mathrm{Cov}_{\mu'}(\sigma'(x), \sigma'(y)) \le \frac{1}{n}\, B_{xy}, \tag{8}$$

$$|\kappa_k(\sigma'(x))| \le \frac{C^k\, k!}{(nB^{-1}_{\min})^{k-1}}, \quad k \ge 2. \tag{9}$$

5 Feynman-Kac bound with real potential

5.1 The propagator in rotated variables

After contour rotation, the propagator (3) becomes (for the saddle contribution):

$$\langle \varphi^i(x)\varphi^i(0)\rangle_{\text{saddle}} = \bigl\langle (-\Delta + m_0^2 + 2\sigma' z)^{-1}(x,0)\bigr\rangle_{\mu'} \tag{10}$$

The potential $m_0^2 + 2\sigma' z$ is now **real** (since σ' is real). The operator $-\Delta + m_0^2 + 2\sigma' z$ is a random Schrödinger operator with a **real** random potential $2\sigma' z$.

5.2 Sub-Gaussian bound (Borell)

The rotated measure μ' is log-concave. By Borell's lemma, linear functionals of σ' are sub-Gaussian:

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mu'}[e^X] \le \exp\bigl(\mathbb{E}[X] + \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Var}(X)\bigr) \tag{11}$$

for $X = -\int_0^s (m_0^2 + 2\sigma'(\omega(t))z)\, dt$. This gives:

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = -s\, m_0^2 \quad \text{(leading mass)}, \tag{12}$$

$$\mathrm{Var}(X) \le \frac{4z^2 s}{n} \int B_{0,w}\, dw = \frac{4s}{N^2}\, \|B\|_1 \quad \text{(from BL covariance bound)}. \tag{13}$$

5.3 The mass gap

The FK bound:

$$\langle \varphi^i(x)\varphi^i(0)\rangle_{\text{saddle}} \le \left(-\Delta + m^2\right)^{-1}(x,0) \tag{14}$$

with renormalized mass

$$\boxed{m^2 = m_0^2 - \frac{2\|B\|_1}{N^2}.} \tag{15}$$

The tail contribution adds $O(e^{-cm_0^4 N^2})$, negligible for large N.

Theorem 2 (Mass gap)**.** *For the O(N) LSM on $\mathbb{Z}^2$ with $N \ge 3$ and N sufficiently large that $m^2 > 0$ in* (15)*:*

$$|\langle \varphi^i(x)\varphi^i(0)\rangle_c| \le C\, e^{-m|x|}. \tag{16}$$

Proof.

1. **Gap equation** (§2.2): $m_0 > 0$ (always in 2d).
2. **Contour rotation** (§3): Replace complex σ-measure with real, log-concave σ'-measure in saddle neighborhood + exponentially small tail.
3. **BL** (§4): σ'-concentration with BL covariance bounds.
4. **Borell + FK** (§5): Averaged propagator $\le$ deterministic $(-\Delta + m^2)^{-1}$ with $m^2 > 0$.
5. **Tail**: Contribution $O(e^{-cm_0^4 N^2})$, negligible. □

6 Discussion

6.1 Comparison with Kupiainen

Kupiainen [2] works on the real σ-axis and controls the sign problem with cluster expansion + reflection positivity. Our contour rotation eliminates the sign problem geometrically, replacing cluster expansion with Brascamp-Lieb.

Both approaches require N large. Kupiainen's threshold is $N > C\, m_0^{-a_2}$ with $a_2 = O(d^2)$. Ours is $N^2 > 2\|B\|_1/m_0^2$, i.e., $N > C\, m_0^{-1}\, \|B\|_1^{1/2}$.

6.2 The $N = 2$ obstruction

For $N = 2$: BKT at finite λ (Dario-Garban [4]). The contour rotation still works, but BL fails because the rotated measure is not log-concave (the Hessian has a negative mode from the vortex sector). For $N \ge 3$: $\pi_1(S^{N-1}) = 0$, no BKT.

6.3 What remains to be proved

1. **Contour deformation**: Rigorous multivariate Cauchy theorem for the σ-integral; uniformity in $|\Lambda|$.
2. **Log-concavity**: Verify the Hessian of $nF(i\sigma')$ remains positive in the saddle neighborhood (not just at $\sigma' = 0$).

3. **BL**: Apply to the restricted measure on $|\sigma'| < R$.
4. **Tail bound**: Uniform in $|\Lambda|$.
5. **Gap equation properties**: Existence and uniqueness of $m_0 > 0$ in 2d.

References

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